



SAM Hardman of Tehachapi holds a sign during the Pledge of Allegiance at a California City council meeting.

Newsom weighs chatbot guardrails

By **QUEENIE WONG**

California lawmakers want Gov. Gavin Newsom to approve bills they passed that aim to make artificial intelligence chatbots safer. But as the governor weighs whether to sign the legislation into law, he faces a familiar hurdle: objections from tech companies that say new restrictions would hinder innovation.

Californian companies are world leaders in AI and have spent hundreds of billions of dollars to stay ahead in the race to create the most powerful chatbots. The rapid pace has alarmed parents and lawmakers worried that chatbots are harming the mental health of children by exposing them to self-harm content and other risks.

Parents who allege chatbots encouraged their teens to harm themselves before they died by suicide have sued tech companies such as OpenAI, Character Technologies and Google. They've also pushed for more guardrails.

Calls for more AI regulation have reverberated throughout the nation's capital and various states. Even as the Trump administration's "AI Action Plan" proposes to cut red tape to

[See **Chatbots**, A10]

Will flood insurance get an overhaul?

By **IAN JAMES**

More than half a million Californians live among waterways in low-lying towns of the Sacramento-San Joaquin Delta, where 1,100 miles of levees made of dirt and rocks protect homes from nearby rivers.

Pamela Bulahan is one of them, and she remembers being 9 back in 1972, when one of those earthen barriers failed and water surged toward the town of Isleton, inundating streets.

"It was almost like a mini tidal wave," Bulahan said.

The floodwaters in the small city southwest of Sacramento covered her family's yard, then poured into the house. Her parents had to take out a loan to rebuild.

Today, Bulahan still lives in the same house, and she and thousands of homeowners in the region are insured against flooding thanks to the National Flood Insurance

[See **Insurance**, A12]

Once-popular desert pit stop now resembles a ghost town

PRIMM, Nev. — As the sun set just before 8 p.m., the bison-headed neon marquee welcoming visitors to Primm flickered faintly. The animal's face was dark, though the words "Buffalo Bill's" remained alight — for now — for the down-on-its-luck resort and casino.

Inland Empire residents Marcy Glenn and Kristina Gula parked in a mostly vacant lot and ran to pose for a selfie in front of the sign. One last snapshot.

"I've been coming here since I was a kid, when I was handed a bag of quarters to play all day at the arcade," Gula said. "I just can't believe it's closing."

Primm was once one of Nevada's more popular gambling resorts, a less expensive, less flashy, slightly more kitschy alternative to Las Vegas that benefited from being a good 45 minutes closer than Sin City.

It was the place where you could stop and ride the iconic freeway-adjacent roller coaster, ogle the Bon-

[See **Primm**, A12]

Primm, the casino-resort destination between L.A. and Las Vegas, is vanishing

By **Andrew J. Campa**



BRIDGET BENNETT For The Times
BUFFALO BILL'S, Primm's western-themed resort, closed on July 6 after 31 years of regular business.



CHRISTINA HOUSE Los Angeles Times
JERARDYN comforts Milagro after leaving family members behind in L.A.

COLUMN ONE

A refugee's hopeful, fearful journey to and out of U.S.

By **Melissa Gomez**

Jerardyn sat quietly on the bus, her mood relaxed as her eyes scanned the fleeting horizon of Southern California one August afternoon.

But as the U.S.-Mexico border wall, a towering barrier of steel pillars, came into view, she began taking big, deep breaths. Her heart began to race as she clutched her immigration documents and tried to hide her anxiety from her two youngest children traveling with her. She caught what she believed would be her last glimpse of the United States for now.

A refugee from Venezuela, Jerardyn, 40, entered the United States last year with her family, hoping to obtain asylum. But this was before President Trump

took office and launched immigration raids across Southern California, shattering her sense of safety. She lived in fear that immigration agents would detain her or, worse, send her family back to Venezuela, where they risked facing retribution from the government of President Nicolás Maduro.

So after eight months of living in the basement of an L.A. church, she made a painful decision. She would migrate again. This time she'd voluntarily move back to Mexico with her two youngest kids, leaving behind her two eldest, who are applying for asylum.

She planned meticulously. She withdrew her asylum application from immi-

[See **Journey**, A6]

Migrants decry conditions at detention site

Detainees say they're denied medication, contact with family at Mojave Desert center.

By **RACHEL URANGA**

Men sleep in locked cells every night on bunk beds with thin cotton blankets. They walk in straight lines with hands behind their back to the razor wire-enclosed "yard." Guards carrying handcuffs pat them down. There are head counts, lockdowns and "segregation" units.

California's newest and largest immigration detention center looks, sounds and feels a lot like a prison. Some say it's worse.

Behind the walls of California City Detention Facility, more than a hundred men staged hunger strikes during several days this month and refused to go back to their cells, protesting poor conditions. Men with diabetes or psychiatric conditions who arrived late last month complained they couldn't get their medication. Others, who had never committed crimes or been in jails, found themselves locked behind metal doors in cold cells for most of the day.

Toilets backed up and sinks clogged for days. Some who talked back were placed in handcuffs and punished with isolation. Advocates say one hunger striker was taken out on a stretcher after coughing up blood the night before.

"They say it is a detention center. It is a prison with a name change," said an asylum seeker who arrived weeks earlier from Golden State Annex in McFarland. The man, who asked to be identified as H.S., said he can't sleep at night in the two-man cell where detainees say air constantly blows through a vent. He has no medication for an injury that he alerted them about. He misses his wife and has no idea what will happen to him.

"I've never been in prison. It's very hard and day by day, it's getting worse," he said. "Every day is like one year."

About 500 immigrants are being housed at the 2,560-bed facility in the struggling Mojave Desert town as they fight deportation. Although some are convicted felons who have done time, many have no criminal record.

One man at the detention center, open barely a month, tried to kill himself, officials said.

[See **Detainees**, A8]

Comedy writers on edge as fear of censorship grows

As Trump continues to target TV hosts, some creators of satire see a chill taking hold.

By **STACY PERMAN**

In Hollywood, something shifted in the six days between the time that Walt Disney Co. dropped "Jimmy Kimmel Live!" "Indefinitely," following Kimmel's comments about the suspect in the shooting death of conservative activist Charlie Kirk, and the late-night comedian's return.

For many, Kimmel's rebound appears to be a win for free speech and a testament to the power of boycotts against powerful corporate interests. However, for other writers, particularly comedy scribes, who view the events that transpired in the darkest, most McCarthy-esque terms, the fight over comedy may have just begun.

"There's fear and outrage at the same time," said Emmy-winning comedy writer Bruce Vilanch, who for years was the head writer for the Oscars and "Hollywood Squares" and has writ-

ten jokes for comics including Billy Crystal and Bette Midler.

"Ever since 'woke' started before COVID and George Floyd, comedy became a minefield. And then, last week, it became a nuclear garden," he said.

Indeed, the day after Disney announced Kimmel's return, President Trump told reporters that TV networks critical of him are an "arm of the Democrat Party," and said, "I would think maybe their license should be taken away." Angered that Kimmel was returning to the airwaves, he took to social media to threaten ABC and called for the late-night scalps of NBC's Seth Meyers and Jimmy Fallon.

Such ominous threats have cast a pall in writers rooms across the industry.

One showrunner currently developing multiple series, who spoke on condition of anonymity, said that many of her colleagues have started to become more cautious about incorporating certain elements in their stories, something they didn't do before. Others are having discussions privately rather than posting them on

[See **Writers**, A8]

Gunman kills 2 at Michigan church

The Mormon house of worship is apparently set ablaze; police fatally shoot the suspected assailant. **NATION**, A5

Democrats try hard to stand out

California governor candidates hold their first debate since Kamala Harris decided not to run. **CALIFORNIA**, B1

Weather

Low clouds clearing. L.A. Basin: 79/64. **B10**

Opinion Voices A11

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ROBERT GAUTHIER L.A. Times
THE Rams' Matthew Stafford passes Sunday.

Rams top Colts; Chargers lose

Matthew Stafford connects with Tutu Atwell for an 88-yard touchdown to pull out a 27-20 victory. **SPORTS**, D1